2.3.5 Providing examples

Providing examples is an excellent way to guide the desired output of an LLM. There are numerous ways to demonstrate examples to an LLM. The system message/prompt can be a helpful way to emphasize general output. In the following listing, the example is added as the last LLM assistant reply, given the prompt “Teach me about Python.”

Listing 2.13 `providing_examples.jsonl`

```
[
    {
        "role": "system",
        "content": """
Answer all replies in a consistent style that follows the format,
length and style of your previous responses.
Example:
  user:
       Teach me about Python.
  assistant:                                                  #1
       Python is a programming language developed in 1989
 by Guido van Rossum.

  Future replies:
       The response was only a sentence so limit
 all future replies to a single sentence.
"""                                                  #2
    },
    {
        "role": "user",
        "content": "Teach me about Java."
    }
]
```

#1 Injects the sample output as the “previous” assistant reply
#2 Adds a limit output tactic to restrict the size of the output and match the example

Providing examples can also be used to request a particular output format from a complex series of tasks that derive the output. For example, asking an LLM to produce code that matches a sample output is an excellent use of examples. We’ll employ this tactic throughout the book, but other methods exist for guiding output.

2.3.6 Specifying output length

The tactic of specifying output length can be helpful in not just limiting tokens but also in guiding the output to a desired format. Listing 2.14 shows an example of using two different techniques for this tactic. The first